

Case Study #1 - Office 365 Termination Phishing Email

Executive Summary

A phishing email with the subject "CONFIRM TERMINATION" was identified and subsequently removed by the University of New Haven Information Technology Department. The email attempted to create urgency by claiming the recipient's Office 365 account required verification to avoid termination. Investigation revealed that the embedded hyperlink redirected users to a Google Forms page titled "IT HELP DESK." Based on the collected evidence, the email is assessed as a credential harvesting and information gathering phishing campaign.

Incident Overview

Date Observed: 3rd June 2026

Email Subject:
CONFIRM TERMINATION

Sender:
e@unh.newhaven.edu

Reported By:
University of New Haven automated phishing remediation notification

Severity:
High

Threat Category:
Phishing / Credential Harvesting

Timeline

Date/Time Event

- 03 Jun 2026 Phishing email received with the subject "CONFIRM TERMINATION".
- 03 Jun 2026 Email reviewed and initial phishing indicators identified.
- 04 Jun 2026 Embedded URL extracted and expanded from forms.gle to Google Forms.
- 04 Jun 2026 URLScan analysis performed on the destination URL.
- 04 Jun 2026 Landing page analyzed and credential collection fields identified.
- 04 Jun 2026 University remediation notice received confirming the email was malicious.
- 04 Jun 2026 Incident classified as a high-confidence credential harvesting phishing campaign.

Initial Indicators

Several indicators suggested the email was malicious:

- Fear and urgency-based language
- Threat of account termination
- Request for account verification
- Generic messaging
- Mismatch between the stated purpose and actual destination

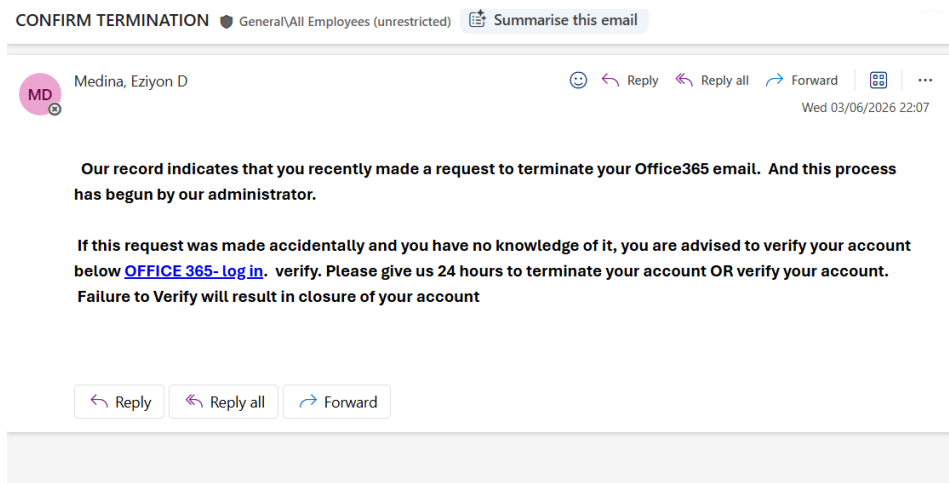


Figure 1: Phishing email titled "CONFIRM TERMINATION" requesting Office 365 account verification.

The email instructed users to verify their Office 365 account to avoid account closure.

Email Header Analysis

Header review identified the following:

From:

e@unh.newhaven.edu

Authentication Results:

- DKIM: none
- DMARC: none

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Received: from C01PR02MB8620.namprd02.prod.outlook.com (2603:10b6:303:15f::8) by PH0PR02MB7205.namprd02.prod.outlook.com (2603:10b6:610:f8::24) by Jun 202602:07:31 +0000Authentication-Results: dkim=none (message not signed) header.d=none; dmarc=none action=none header.from=unh.newhaven.edu; Received: from CH0PR02MB8274.namprd02.prod.outlook.com (2603:10b6:610:f8::24) by
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Figure 2: Email authentication results showing missing DKIM and DMARC validation

Exchange Indicators:

- X-MS-Exchange-Organization-AuthAs: Internal
- X-MS-Exchange-CrossTenant-AuthAs: Internal

These headers suggest the message originated from an authenticated internal Microsoft 365 account. One possible explanation is that the sender account had been compromised and used to distribute phishing emails.

URL Analysis

Embedded URL:

hxxps://forms[.]gle/16PMRGhmVbrD12ZR9

URL Expansion:

hxxps://docs[.]google[.]com/forms/d/e/1FAIpQLSfNdli6Wv_cJIpOYnTE27dZ7PZsm7sI8pE516FA4_8FDeLENw/viewform

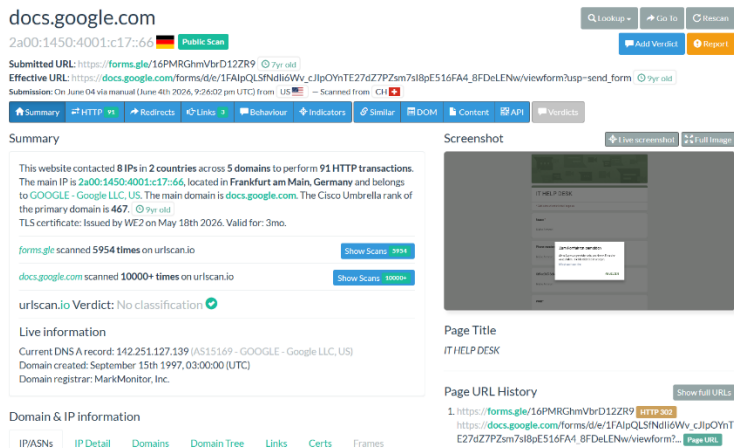


Figure 3: URLScan results showing the expanded Google Forms destination.

URLScan Findings:

- Hosted on Google infrastructure
- Valid TLS certificate
- Domain reputation appeared legitimate
- No infrastructure-based indicators of compromise

Analysis determined the destination was a Google Form rather than a Microsoft authentication portal.

Landing Page Analysis

The destination page was titled:

Form Title:

IT HELP DESK

The form required users to authenticate with a Google account before accessing the form contents.

Observed Fields:

- Name
- Phone Number
- Office365 School Email
- PWD (Password)

- Previous University/College Attended
- Previous University Email Address

Figure 4. Google Form landing page used in the phishing campaign.

A significant finding was the inconsistency between the phishing lure and the destination. The email claimed to perform Office 365 account verification; however, users were redirected to a Google Form hosted on Google infrastructure.

This mismatch is a common phishing indicator.

University Response

The University of New Haven Information Technology Department issued a remediation notification indicating:

- The email was identified as potentially harmful
- The email was removed from user mailboxes
- Users who submitted credentials were instructed to change their passwords immediately

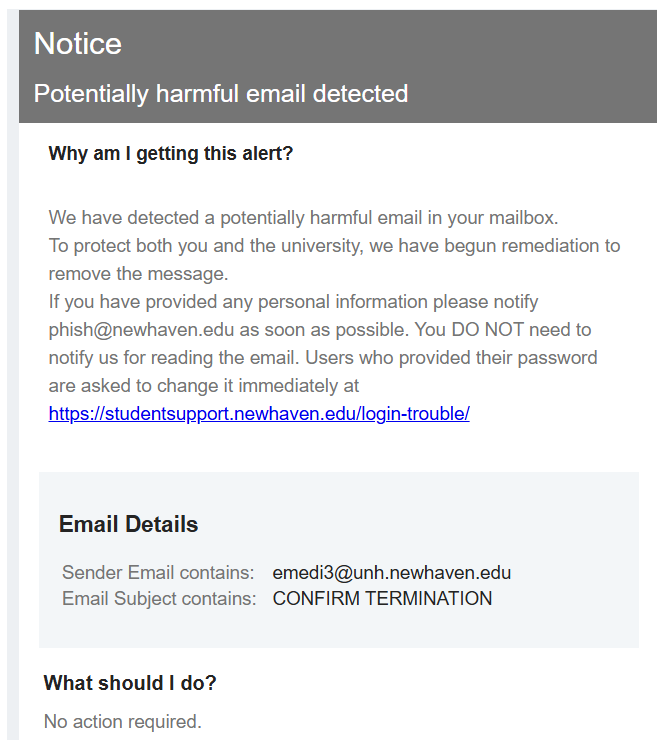


Figure 5. University remediation notice confirming removal of the phishing email.

This organizational response significantly increased confidence that the message was malicious.

Indicators of Compromise (IOCs)

Email Indicators

Subject:

CONFIRM TERMINATION

Sender Email:

emedi3@unh.newhaven.edu

Sender Display Name:

Medina, Eziyon D

URL Indicators

Original URL:

<https://forms.gle/16PMRGhmVbrD12ZR9>

Expanded URL:

https://docs.google.com/forms/d/e/1FAIpQLSfNdli6Wv_cJIpOYnTE27dZ7PZsm7sI8pE516FA4_8FDeLENw/viewform

Domain Indicators

forms[.]gle

docs[.]google[.]com

Form Indicators

Form Title:

IT HELP DESK

Credential Collection Fields:

- Office365 School Email
- PWD (Password)

Additional Data Collection Fields:

- Name
- Phone Number
- Previous University/College Attended
- Previous University Email Address

Header Indicators

Authentication Results:

- DKIM: none
- DMARC: none

Internal Authentication Headers:

- X-MS-Exchange-Organization-AuthAs: Internal
- X-MS-Exchange-CrossTenant-AuthAs: Internal

Social Engineering Indicators

- Account termination threat
- Urgency-based messaging
- Office 365 account verification lure
- Generic IT support impersonation
- Mismatch between Office 365 verification claim and Google Forms destination

Organizational Validation

University of New Haven Information Technology Department identified the email as potentially harmful and removed it from affected mailboxes.

MITRE ATT&CK Mapping

Tactic:

Credential Access

Technique:

T1566 - Phishing

Possible Objectives:

- Credential Harvesting
- Information Gathering
- Account Compromise

Evidence Supporting Classification:

- Collection of Office365 School Email addresses
- Collection of Passwords (PWD)
- Fraudulent account verification theme
- Mismatch between stated purpose and destination platform

Conclusion

The investigation identified a phishing campaign that used an account termination theme to pressure users into providing credentials. The phishing email directed recipients to a Google Form titled "IT HELP DESK" that requested Office 365 email addresses and passwords. The use of a legitimate Google Forms service increased the perceived legitimacy of the attack while allowing the threat actor to collect credentials directly from victims.

Based on the collected evidence and the subsequent remediation actions taken by the University of New Haven Information Technology Department, the campaign is assessed as a high-confidence credential harvesting attack.

Remediation Actions

1. Remove the phishing email from affected user mailboxes to prevent additional users from interacting with the malicious content.
2. Reset passwords and revoke active sessions for any users who submitted credentials through the phishing form.
3. Investigate the sender account for signs of compromise and review authentication logs for suspicious activity.
4. Block or monitor the identified phishing URLs and educate users on recognizing similar phishing attempts.

Lessons Learned

- Trusted domains do not guarantee trusted content.
- Google Forms can be abused for phishing campaigns.
- Urgency and account termination themes remain effective social engineering techniques.
- Internal accounts can be used to distribute phishing emails if compromised.
- URL expansion and landing-page analysis are critical steps in phishing investigations.